Farès Zaghouane

Machine Learning Research Engineer · MSc EPFL

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SUMMARY

Machine learning research engineer (MSc EPFL, 2026) working between representation learning and dynamical systems. At Apple I formalized hardware behavior as reachable-state specifications; at Nokia Bell Labs I built focus-map prediction for cloud-gaming video, where predictions drift once the semantic anchor becomes sparse. That failure mode led me to the question I work on now: how the representation space and the predictor of a world model should be designed together so that planning becomes more stable and cheaper to run.

WHAT DRIVES ME

How a machine can learn a model of the world good enough to plan with, and how to tell when that model can be trusted. I learn by rebuilding methods from the mathematics up, and I am drawn to questions that cross fields: control theory, physics-inspired structure, energy-based models, neuroscience.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Keywords: World models · JEPA predictors · latent dynamical systems · state-space models · Koopman-style spectral structure · energy-based models · latent geometry · representation learning · planning and control.

In joint-embedding predictive architectures, the encoder learns what to represent while the predictor models how representations evolve; that predictor is typically an unconstrained network. I tested whether explicit dynamical structure helps on a system where the prior is exactly correct after a change of basis. A first cycle, still in progress and with the representation held fixed, separates what depends on the transition family from what depends on the coordinates in which the prior is imposed. What I want to build next is a diagnostic framework that reveals when structure pays: which modes persist, how much stability margin remains before rollouts diverge, and which latent directions actions can reach.

EXPERIENCE

Nokia Bell Labs Stuttgart, Germany

Research Intern (MSc Thesis) *Aug 2025 – Feb 2026*

- An under-specified research problem: first decide what to predict and how to measure whether it helps. The target became dense focus maps predicted from cloud-gaming video, to allocate bandwidth and quality; the design aimed at a strict per-frame latency budget.
- No dataset existed for the task. Designed with my supervisor a metric that makes training possible without hand-annotated ground truth; built the data engine alone: about 2k semi-manually annotated keyframes were used to fine-tune a VLM that drives automatic labeling of about 2 h of gameplay (12 games, 4 genres).
- Started from a JEPA-style model propagating the latent state to predict the next focus maps; dropped it under the latency, compute and dataset constraints, and derived a teacher–student pipeline combining Grounding DINO semantic anchoring, RAFT optical-flow propagation, and a lightweight correction network.
- Also tried state-space models and Mamba-Vision encoders; designed the pseudo-supervision setup, tracked temporal drift and built the dense-map evaluation protocol. The retained hybrid runs the semantic model on one frame in eight: an estimated 5× cost cut versus the per-frame semantic model, and it beats the motion-only and saliency-only baselines. Team of three: two research engineers supervising, and me.

Apple Munich, Germany

Design Verification Research Intern *Oct 2022 – Jul 2023*

- Modeled IP behavior using finite-state machines and event-based abstractions, allowing long-running processes to be reasoned about without expanding every low-level timing step.
- Applied model checking to behaviors that simulation cannot cover exhaustively, and built Python tooling that generates Verilog/SystemVerilog assertions from high-level specs for a commercial model checker; tested it on industrial designs already verified by hand, with injected bugs.
- The event-based abstraction sets the level at which reachable states are specified, which changed which properties were practical to verify. A research project in a 30-person team, carried out mainly by me with one engineer supervising.

PROJECTS

Structured Latent Dynamics *(in progress)*

Factorial study of structured dynamical priors in the latent predictor of a JEPA world model: Koopman-style 2×2 rotation-scaling blocks against MLP, transformer and selective-SSM predictors on coupled oscillators, whose true generator belongs to the structured family after a change of basis. Arms are paired within backbone. The first cycle localizes the effect of the prior: least squares recovers the planted operator, and an oracle-basis arm measures how much depends on the basis in which the prior is imposed.

Constrained Trace EBM *(in progress)*

Energy-based scoring of finite-state-machine execution traces against temporal specifications, with an exact symbolic checker as ground truth and decision thresholds fixed before training. In the first cycle, detection on machines never seen in training clears its preset floor (bootstrap lower bound 0.772 against 0.75); the next cycle targets the cases where reading the specification is required.

RL from Scratch

From-scratch PyTorch RL curriculum: 25 algorithms from tabular Q-learning to PPO/SAC, Dreamer, MuZero, and an action-conditioned JEPA world model inspired by V-JEPA 2-AC, each taught in a course-style notebook then refactored onto a shared runtime. HalfCheetah-v5: SAC/TD3 ≈10k, DDPG ≈11k near 1M steps.

Machine Learning from Scratch

From-scratch ML curriculum: 52 course-style notebooks and a 123-module scikit-learn-style library. Each chapter takes one model apart rather than only re-implementing it: every equation term, every hyperparameter, and why one design supersedes the last. Runs from a custom autograd engine through Transformers, SSMs, GNNs and generative models to optimal transport and Riemannian optimization.

GPT-2 from Scratch

PyTorch GPT-2-style decoder-only Transformer built against the original papers: tokenization, embeddings, causal multi-head attention, transformer blocks, pretraining, generation, fine-tuning.

VLM Data Engine

Video data pipeline for multimodal world-model experiments: shard processing, FPS conversion, scene detection, clip extraction, annotation, and quality checks.

EDUCATION

École Polytechnique Fédérale de Lausanne (EPFL) — Lausanne, Switzerland

MSc Computer Science, Machine Learning specialization — *Sept 2023 – 2026*

Relevant coursework: Artificial Neural Networks & Reinforcement Learning, Computer Vision, Machine Learning, Natural Language Processing, ML in Finance, Cryptography & Security.

CPE Lyon — Lyon, France

Diplôme d'Ingénieur, Computer Science, Software Engineering & Big Data track — *Sept 2021 – 2026*

CPE Lyon — Lyon, France

Licence (BSc), Computer Science & Electronics — *Sept 2020 – Sept 2021*

SKILLS

ML & representation learning: PyTorch, TensorFlow, Neural networks, Self-supervised learning, JEPA / world models, Energy-based models

Vision & multimodal systems: Computer vision, Video understanding, Grounding DINO, RAFT / optical flow, Focus-map prediction, Multimodal data pipelines

Dynamics, control & RL: Reinforcement learning, State-space models, Mamba, Koopman-style spectral constraints, Dynamical systems

Mathematical & scientific foundations: Linear algebra, Applied statistics, Signal processing, Optimization, Spectral methods, Functional analysis

Software & formal methods: Python, NumPy, Formal verification, Model checking, Finite-state machines, Verilog / SystemVerilog assertions

Languages: French (native), English (C1, Cambridge CAE)